



POLES

LIKE OTHER COUNTRIES IN EASTERN EUROPE, Poland was badly damaged by World War II (1939–1945), and shortly afterward adopted communism. Unfortunately, the country also suffered for many years under communist rule. The Polish

A DEVOUTLY RELIGIOUS PEOPLE

Ethnically and religiously unified

The borders of the country that is modern Poland have changed in significant ways since the 10th century. Despite this, nearly all of its population is ethnically Polish, which makes Poland the most racially uniform country in Europe. Almost the entire population is also Roman Catholic, with three-quarters actively practicing their religion. Polish people are extremely proud that the current Pope, John Paul II, is a Pole and former Archbishop of Krakow.

SOCIALIST HOUSING

During the communist era enormous, identical apartment blocks were built in Poland and other communist countries. It was believed that identical homes would make people feel equal.



FIRST COMMUNION

By the time they are eight or nine, Polish children will have experienced their First Communion. On this day girls in white dresses and veils, and boys in dark suits participate fully in the Catholic Mass for the first time.



MUSHROOM PICKING

Historically, mushrooms were the great equalizer in the Polish diet; growing wild they were available to rich and poor alike. To this day, mushroom picking is a favored Polish pastime.